

Cherry

Prunus serrulata (and related ornamental cultivars)



Origin

New York's street cherries are mostly cultivated ornamental varieties bred from Japanese and Asian wild cherry species, popularized worldwide after Japan gifted flowering cherries to Washington, D.C. in 1912.

Look for

Look for horizontal dashes across smooth, reddish-brown bark -- these lenticels (breathing pores) are one of the clearest identifying marks across almost all ornamental cherry varieties.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Bark: smooth, reddish-brown, with horizontal dash-like lenticels.
- Flower: pink or white blossoms in dense clouds, often before leaves open.
- Leaf: oval, toothed edge.
- Commonly confused with: schubert cherry (ordinary street cherries keep green leaves all summer, while schubert cherry's leaves shift to purple).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Clouds of pink or white blossoms, often before leaves fully open.
Summer	Oval, toothed green leaves.
Fall	Leaves can turn orange to bronze.
Winter	Smooth bark with distinct horizontal lenticel lines is easy to spot.

DID YOU KNOW

- Many ornamental street cherries are sterile or produce very little fruit, since they were bred for flowers rather than fruit production.
- Cherry blossom festivals, like the famous ones in Washington D.C. and Japan, celebrate blooms that typically last only about one to two weeks.